Editor's Guide — Multilanguage Features

A step-by-step guide for **content editors and site administrators** who publish or maintain multilingual content with the Simple Translation Manager plugin.

No coding knowledge is required. If you can use the WordPress post editor and the block/classic editor, you can translate content with this plugin.

> **Who this is for:** WordPress editors, authors, and administrators. **Not covered here:** theme integration, REST API, WP-CLI — see `../API.md` and `../CLI-COMMANDS.md`.

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For problems, see `TROUBLESHOOTING.md`.

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1. Basic Concepts

Before you translate your first post, it helps to understand three ideas the plugin is built around: **languages**, **translation groups**, and **language detection**.

1.1 Languages

The plugin ships with **English** and **Dutch** enabled by default. Any number of additional languages can be configured under **WP Admin → Translations → Languages**.

Each language has:

Field	Example	Purpose
Code	`en`, `nl`, `fr`	Internal ID used in URLs and the database
Name	`English`	Label shown in admin menus
Native name	`Español`	Label shown in language switchers
Flag emoji	ES	Optional visual in the switcher
Default	✅ / ⬜	One language must be marked as default

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/01-languages-list.png` *Caption: The **Languages** screen lists every language, its flag, code, and which one is the default.*

1.2 Translation Groups

A **translation group** is an invisible link that ties together all versions of the same piece of content.

Example: you write a post in English called **"About Us"**. You then add a Dutch translation called **"Over Ons"** and a French translation called **"À Propos"**. The plugin assigns all three a shared translation group ID (a UUID), so it knows they represent the same page in three languages.

Translation groups are created **automatically** the first time you save a translation. You never need to manage them manually.

What the translation group enables:

- The language switcher on the frontend can jump between the three versions.
- If a visitor requests the French version of "About Us", WordPress knows to serve the French post instead of the English one.
- Editing any one of them keeps the link intact — you don't need to re-associate them.

1.3 Language Detection & URL Structure

When a visitor loads your site, the plugin decides which language to show in this priority order:

1. `?lang=` **URL parameter** — highest priority, e.g. `/about/?lang=nl`
2. **Session** — a temporary memory for the current browser session
3. **Cookie** — remembers the visitor's choice for 30 days
4. **Default language** — the one marked as default in **Languages**

URL patterns you will see:

URL	Language served
`https://example.com/about/`	Default language (typically English)
`https://example.com/about/?lang=nl`	Dutch
`https://example.com/about/?lang=fr`	French

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/02-url-switching.png` *Caption: The same post served in English and Dutch by appending* `?lang=nl`.

A language switcher widget/shortcode handles this for visitors automatically — they click a flag, and the `?lang=` parameter is appended for them.

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2. Adding Translations to a Post or Page

This is the everyday workflow. It works for **posts, pages, and any public custom post type** on your site.

2.1 Step-by-Step: Translate an Existing Post

Step 1 — Open the post in the editor

Go to **Posts** → **All Posts** (or **Pages** → **All Pages**) and click the post you want to translate. A new column called **Language** shows you the current language of each post at a glance.

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/03-posts-list-language-column.png` *Caption: The **Language** column on the All Posts screen — look for the flag and language code next to each post title.*

Step 2 — Locate the "Translations" meta box

Scroll down below the main editor area. You will see a meta box titled **"Translations"**.

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/04-translations-metabox.png` *Caption: The Translations meta box sits below the content editor. The top of the box shows the current post's language.*

Step 3 — Confirm the post's current language

At the top of the meta box, the field **"This post is written in:"** shows the current language. If the default is wrong (e.g. you wrote the post in Dutch but the dropdown says English), correct it here before adding translations.

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/05-current-language-selector.png` *Caption: Set the source language correctly — translations are added **into other languages**, so this dropdown tells the plugin what the original is.*

Step 4 — Click a language tab

Below the source-language selector, you see one tab per additional language — e.g. NL **Dutch**, FR **French**. Click the tab for the language you want to translate **into**.

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/06-language-tabs.png` *Caption: One tab per target language. The active tab is highlighted.*

Step 5 — Fill in the translated fields

Each tab contains four fields:

Field	What to enter
Title	The translated post title
Slug	The URL-friendly slug in that language (e.g. `over-ons`)
Excerpt	The translated short description
Content	The full translated body — uses the rich text editor

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/07-translation-tab-fields.png` *Caption: All four fields for a target language, including a rich-text editor for the content body.*

Leave a field empty if you don't have a translation yet — see Partial Translations in Best Practices.

Step 6 — Click Update (or Publish)

Click WordPress's normal **Update** or **Publish** button at the top right. The translations are saved at the same time as the rest of the post.

Step 7 — Verify on the frontend

Open the post on the frontend, then append `?lang=<code>` to the URL to check the translated version. Example: `https://example.com/about/?lang=nl`.

2.2 Creating a New Post in a Non-Default Language

You can also author a post directly in, say, French:

1. Create the post as usual with **Add New**.
2. In the Translations meta box, change **"This post is written in:"** to **French**.
3. Add translations into English, Dutch, etc. in the other tabs.
4. Publish.

The post's primary language will be French; other languages become the translations.

2.3 Translating Categories, Tags, and Taxonomies

Category and tag translations are edited from **WP Admin** → **Translations** → **Strings**, or by editing the term itself when the plugin's term-translation fields are present. The frontend automatically swaps term names and slugs based on the current language.

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3. Translating Custom Fields (ACF / Pods) & Page Builders (Elementor)

The Simple Translation Manager plugin translates the **core WordPress post fields** — title, slug, excerpt, and `post_content` — out of the box. It does not ship with dedicated integrations for ACF, Pods, or Elementor, but there are two supported approaches for content editors:

3.1 Approach A — One Full Translation Per Language (Recommended)

This is the simplest approach and works for **every** field type, including Elementor layouts and ACF repeaters.

1. Create the original post (e.g. in English) with all its ACF fields, Pods fields, or Elementor layout filled in.
2. In the Translations meta box, click the tab for the target language.
3. In the **Content** field for that language, paste the translated equivalent. For Elementor-built pages this usually means creating a **separate page** (see Approach B).
4. Update.

> **Tip:** If you use Elementor extensively on a page, treat each language as its own page linked through the translation group — see Approach B below.

3.2 Approach B — Separate Pages Joined by a Translation Group

For Elementor-heavy pages or complex ACF layouts, it is often cleaner to create one WordPress page per language and let the translation group link them.

1. Build the original page in Elementor (e.g. `/about/` in English).
2. Create a new page for each target language — e.g. `/over-ons/` for Dutch, `/a-propos/` for French. Design each page in that language's Elementor canvas.

3. On each page's Translations meta box:
    - Set **"This post is written in:"** to that page's language.
    - The plugin's admin tooling (**Translations** → **Strings**) lets admins assign them to the same translation group so the language switcher links them correctly.

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/08-separate-pages-strategy.png` *Caption: Three separate pages — one per language — joined by a shared translation group. The language switcher on the frontend moves the visitor between them.*

3.3 ACF / Pods Field Notes

- **Text, textarea, WYSIWYG fields** — translate by duplicating the page (Approach B) and re-entering the field content in the target language.
- **Image, number, date, true/false fields** — usually don't need translation; leave them identical.
- **Repeater / flexible content** — Approach B is strongly recommended; repeater data is stored per-post and is not auto-translated.
- **Shared field groups** — if you use ACF options pages, their values are global and not translated by this plugin. Contact your developer for an options-page translation strategy.

3.4 Elementor-Specific Notes

- Elementor stores its layout in a single `_elementor_data` meta field as JSON. Translating it reliably requires **Approach B** — a separate page per language.
- Templates and global widgets are **not** automatically translated. Use Elementor's own template library to create per-language copies if needed.

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4. Best Practices

4.1 When Should I Create a Translation?

Create a translation when **the visitor experience is better with the translated version than with the original**. Common triggers:

- You publish content in your site's default language and have staff who can translate it reliably.

- You run paid ads or landing pages targeting a specific language/region.
- Legal/marketing copy must exist in every language you serve.

You do **not** need a translation for:

- Short-lived posts (news flashes, internal announcements).
- Content that is identical in every language (e.g. a product image gallery with no text).

4.2 Keep Slugs Localized

Use localized slugs — e.g. `/over-ons/` instead of `/about/?lang=nl`. Localized slugs help SEO and are easier for visitors to recognize and share.

4.3 Partial Translations

A post does not need to be fully translated in every language. If a field (title, excerpt, slug, content) is empty for a given language, the frontend **falls back to the original-language content** for that field.

Practical consequence: you can launch with title + excerpt translated and fill in the full content later. Visitors will still see your translated title on listing pages.

4.4 Review in the Frontend After Every Save

After publishing a translation, always open the page with `?lang=<code>` appended and verify:

- The title appears in the correct language.
- The slug is what you entered.
- The content is complete and correctly formatted.
- The language switcher moves between translations correctly.

4.5 Use the Translations Dashboard for Bulk Work

Translations → **Strings** gives you a searchable list of every translatable string on the site. It is the fastest way to:

- Spot missing translations (empty rows).
- Update a string globally (e.g. changing "Home" → "Dashboard" in all languages).
- Import/export translations in JSON via **Import/Export**.

> **Screenshot placeholder** — `screenshots/09-strings-dashboard.png` *Caption: The Strings dashboard — search, filter by context, and inline-edit any translation.*

4.6 Keep One Editor per Language Where Possible

If your team is large, assigning one editor per language keeps tone and terminology consistent across translations. The plugin doesn't enforce this, but the Language column on the Posts list makes it easy to filter each editor's workload.

4.7 Clear Cache After Bulk Edits

If your site uses a caching plugin (WP Rocket, W3 Total Cache, LiteSpeed Cache, object cache via Redis, etc.), flush the cache after a large batch of translation edits. See `TROUBLESHOOTING.md`.

4.8 Don't Use Machine Translation Without Review

The plugin supports programmatic translation import, but machine-translated content should always be reviewed by a human speaker before publishing. Search engines penalize low-quality auto-translations.

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5. Where to Go Next

- **Something isn't working?** → `TROUBLESHOOTING.md`
- **Developer integration (theme / REST API)** → `../API.md`
- **Bulk imports via WP-CLI** → `../CLI-COMMANDS.md`
- **Overall plugin overview** → `../../README.md`
- **Detailed blog translation reference** → `../../README-BLOG.md`

Appendix A — Screenshots & Video

All screenshots referenced above live in `./screenshots/`. File naming convention: `NN-short-description.png` (two-digit prefix for ordering).

A **5–10 minute video walkthrough** of the end-to-end editor workflow is a deliverable for this documentation pack. Once recorded, place it at `./screenshots/editor-walkthrough.mp4` (or link to an internal video-hosting URL from this section). Suggested chapter markers:

Time	Chapter
0:00	Languages screen tour
1:00	Translating your first post
3:00	Adding a second translation and verifying on the frontend
4:30	Strings dashboard and bulk workflow
6:00	Elementor/ACF considerations
8:00	Troubleshooting and cache clearing

A PDF version of this guide can be generated with any markdown-to-PDF tool (e.g. `pandoc EDITORS_GUIDE.md -o editors-guide.pdf`) and distributed to non-technical stakeholders who prefer offline reading.